The airline officials asked our man to repack the box, and they would take it the next day.

'I can't make the pack smaller, you make the aircraft door big,' he told them.

The airline removed the beading of the door to take the box in and refit the beading before take-off.

An eleven-member team including some from the old Vernon team left for Paris in early December, 1985. Besides me, the old members included P R Sadasivam who later worked on PSLV, H R S Mani, Narendranath and the inimitable Anandan who had a matchless skill in hand-sealing joints. Some joints have to be hand-sealed using a material that one has to apply with the palm. As per the protocol this was a fitter's job, but nobody could get the seal as perfect as Anandan. So much was our dependency on him that Anandan was worried that he would end up being a fitter. Annamma John from the quality control was the only woman member of the team. One not from the previous Vernon team was N K Gupta, an IISc alumnus and an expert in turbo pumps. We also took along Sukumaran Nair, our ace fitter who went on to assemble all the engines till the first flight of PSLV in 1993.

A shock awaited us in France. When the cargo reached Paris, three of the twenty-one boxes were missing. Air India traced them to Copenhagen where the cargo had to be reloaded. The missing boxes came four days later. SEP had given us a ten-day window period for the test. This is because the test has to be carried out only on a windy day to make sure that the flare and fumes dissipate faster. Also, the wind should be blowing from Vernon town towards the test facility, so that the flames don't leap out of the campus. The facility set up in the mid-1940s did not have the 3 km uninhabited buffer zone around the test facility.

The engine was to be fired for the full duration of 180 seconds. Computers were fed with the tolerable limits of various parameters for the system to shut down automatically if something crossed the prescribed threshold. Though we had indigenised many parts of the engine, for this test